

everything that an Indian man wants. Most actors spend years trying to find a niche, and here Vidya was trying to lose it," he says laughing. It's something the alumnus of Mumbai's St. Anthony's Girls High School and St. Xavier's College is aware of. "I conned myself into playing fluffy, floozy type of roles. It's the saddest thing for me to say that I'd begun to feel apologetic about having played Lalita in *Parineeta*. I wanted to prove that I could be a glam doll."

With a disastrous makeover in *Heyy Babyy* and worse experimentation in *Kismat Konnection*, she could feel her hard-won self-assurance slipping away. She became a public spectacle, easy meat for those who revelled in pulling apart her style sense, ridiculing her costume choices on-screen and off. Her family saved her, her father who works for a cable network company and her mother, a homemaker. As did her prayers. "I took off my dark glasses and decided to wear the salwar kameez and sari again," she says. She also got a trainer, gave up her unhealthy eating habits and had some life changing conversations with Balki and her sister.

"She told me it's the easiest to be yourself. It's a constant effort to be someone else."

As she sits in her vanity van in Mumbai's Film City shooting an ad—she endorses five brands—greeting two-film co-star Akshay Kumar who's dropped by, she's happy she's out of the self-destructive phase. She's now enjoying every moment of the work she's getting. Sometimes too much, says Abhishek Chaubey, the director of *Ishqiya*, who would often have to wait for her fit of giggles to subside before he could shoot. "She's

happy-go-lucky and yet fearless in her choices," he says. She's also a team person, happy to hang out on the set even when she doesn't have lines and do each of the 55 interviews lined up to promote a film. Says Raju Hirani, who remembers directing a nervous Balan four years ago in *Lage Raho Munnabhai*, "She would drop by my office and order *chai* for herself. She even came to our *3 Idiots* set

**BALAN PLAYS KRISHNA IN *ISHQIYA*, A WOMAN WHO KNOWS HER MIND AND BODY**



“She stands for a hip traditionality. It's everything an Indian man wants. Most actors spend a lifetime looking for a niche. And she was trying to run away from it.”

R. BALKI, Director, *Paa*

when she was shooting *Paa* on another floor just to play a prank on Boman Irani. She has no airs."

It's something that allows her to observe people unhindered. Add to it a formidable concentration and tremendous preparation. When *Ishqiya* was being shot in Wai, Maharashtra, for over two months, she returned home only once, "because I was completely in the zone". She worked with a dialect coach, with the designer Payal Saluja on the brightly coloured synthetic saris, and learned to say words like *chutiya*-

*sulphate*, a common abuse in eastern Uttar Pradesh, without choking. She's had practice at working hard, having struggled on the periphery of the film industry for two years, being dropped from two regional films, before finally landing *Parineeta*, which director Pradeep Sarkar says was written as much based on her character as it was on Sanjay Dutt's and Saif Ali Khan's. She was a model in over 60 TV commercials, acted in the first season of Zee TV's popular *Hum Paanch* and recalls that director

Anurag Basu wanted to cast her as the lead in a prime time soap at one point. "But I wanted to act in the movies," she says, adding that Basu called her recently to congratulate her on her perseverance.

She's learnt to be comfortable with standing out, like her contemporary Konkona Sen Sharma. "I think an aggressive sexuality is not about your clothes. It's about a look in your eyes, about your attitude," she says. "I don't have a double standard about sex onscreen. Today a lot of love is physical. You can't be *chui-mui* (touchy) about it." Yet she was hesitant about playing Krishna in

*Ishqiya*, because she

thought she could do love but never lust. But what attracted her was that she wasn't a doormat. "All the women I've played, from Sneha in *Halla Bol* to Avni/Monjolika in *Bhool Bhulaiyaa*, live life on their own terms. It's a reflection of how women are today." She hopes to continue her successful strike rate, with Rajkumar Gupta's *No One Killed Jessica* based on Jessica Lall's murder and Vibhu Puri's *Chenab Gandhi*, based on the life of Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan. And oh yes, she promises to never try to be the hot chick. Ever. ■